The American Dream: The American Dream: A Broken Promise?

Target Audience: B1+ / B2 (Upper-Intermediate)
Time: 45-50 minutes
Approach: CLIL + Socio-cultural approach

Lesson Objectives:

- Educational: Analyze the modern economic reality of the American Dream using authentic data and audio.
- Linguistic: Practice vocabulary for expressing opinions, agreeing/disagreeing, and analyzing graphs (e.g., *income gap, tuition fees, social mobility*).
- Socio-cultural: Develop critical thinking by comparing the *myth* of the American Dream with the *reality* of modern US society (Dialogue of Cultures).

Stage	Stage aim	Timing	Procedure	Aids and materials
Warm-up	Activate background knowledge and introduce the economic conflict.	5 min	Show a picture of a typical American house (with a price tag of $500,000) and a university diploma (with a price tag of $100,000). Ask: *"Can a person working a minimum wage job afford these? What does this mean for the American Dream?"*	Pictures of a house and diploma with price tags.
Controlled Practice	Pre-teach vocabulary for expressing opinions and analyzing data.	7 min	Students match words with definitions: *social mobility, income gap, tuition fees, to afford, to struggle*.	Vocabulary Match, presentation slide.
Listening	Develop listening skills for specific information and emotional tone.	10 min	Students listen to a short authentic audio clip. They fill in a table: *Speaker 1 / Speaker 2 / Speaker 3 / Main problem / Do they believe in the Dream?*	Authentic audio [The American dream feels impossible for many young voters, who see no political fix | NCPR News]

Post-Listening	Develop critical thinking through visual data	8 min	Teacher shows an infographic (, "The gap between rich and poor in the US" or "Cost of college vs. Minimum wage"). Students answer 2 questions: *1. What trend do you see? 2. How does this data support or destroy the American Dream?*	Authentic infographic on the screen.
Freer Practice	Apply knowledge and develop speaking skills through a formal debate.	15 min	Divide the class into two teams: Team "Dream" (believes it still works) and Team "Reality" (believes it's a myth). Give them 5 minutes to prepare arguments. Structure: 2 min opening statements, 5 min open discussion, 2 min closing statements.	Debate Structure , Useful Phrases.
Homework and feedback	Summarize, consolidate, and reflect.	5 min	Reflection: *"Which team was more convincing and why?"* Homework: Write a short letter to the editor of a US newspaper (100 words) expressing your view on the American Dream.	Board, students' notebooks.

Vocabulary Match

Task: Match the words (1-5) with their definitions (A-E).

Word	Letter	Definition
1. Social mobility	[ ]	A. The amount of money you have to pay to study at a university.

2. Income gap	[ ]	B. The difference in wealth between the richest and poorest people.
3. Tuition fees	[ ]	C. To have enough money to pay for something.
4. To afford	[ ]	D. The ability of a person to move to a higher social class (e.g., from poor to rich).
5. To struggle	[ ]	E. To try very hard to do something when it is difficult.

1: Vocabulary Match

1. D
2. B
3. A
4. C
5. E

2: Listening Table

Task: Listen to three Americans talking about their lives. Complete the table.

Speaker	**Main Problem (e.g., student debt, rent)**	**Do they believe in the American Dream? (Yes/No/Not sure)**
Speaker 1		
Speaker 2		
Speaker 3		

3: Debate Structure & Useful Phrases

Motion: *"The American Dream is a myth; hard work is no longer enough to succeed in the USA."*

Team A: The Dream is Alive (Affirmative)

- You believe anyone can succeed if they work hard.
- Give examples of successful people who started with nothing.

Team B: The Dream is Dead (Negative)

- You believe the system is unfair (high costs, low wages).
- Give examples of people working hard but staying poor.

Useful Phrases for Debate:

- Expressing an opinion: *In my view... / I strongly believe that... / As far as I'm concerned...*
- Agreeing: *I completely agree with my opponent on this point... / That's a valid point.*
- Disagreeing: *I see your point, but... / I'm afraid I have to disagree... / That's not entirely true because...*
- Asking for clarification: *Could you explain what you mean by...? / Can you give an example?*